Praise of the Perfection of Wisdom

Prajñāpāramitāstotra · Toh 1127 · Derge Tengyur
ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་ཕ་རོལ་ཏུ་ཕྱིན་པའི་བསྟོད་པ

Praise of the Perfection of Wisdom, known in Sanskrit as the Prajñāpāramitāstotra and in Tibetan as Sherab kyi Pharol tu Chinmé Töpa, is a hymn in verse addressed to the Perfection of Wisdom as a feminine presence, the Blessed Lady, who is as inseparable from the buddhas as moonlight is from the moon. Over some twenty verses it praises her as stainless and beyond words, the loving mother of the bodhisattva heroes and so the grandmother of all beings, the one path to liberation relied on by buddhas, solitary buddhas, and hearers, and yet something that neither comes nor goes and that the wise do not find in any place, so that praise itself can only be offered in conventional terms. The Tibetan colophon ascribes it to the master Nāgārjuna, though Sanskrit sources often attribute it to Rāhulabhadra, and records that it was translated by the Kashmiri paṇḍita Tilakakalaśa and the translator Loden Sherab. It is Toh 1127 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: prajñāpāramitastotraṃ. In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Perfection of Wisdom.

Homage to the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom.

You whose whole body is faultless,
You who are beheld by the faultless,
Immeasurable Perfection of Wisdom,
Free of conceptual thought: I pay homage and bow to you.

Like space, you are unstained,
Free of conceptual elaboration, without letters;
Whoever sees you, the inconceivable,
Sees the Tathāgata (the Buddha).

Between you, noble lady rich in qualities,
And the buddhas, the teachers of beings,
No difference is discerned:
It is as with the moon and moonlight.

O you who are loving to the devoted,
Relying on you, the forerunner of the buddhas' qualities,
Those whose very nature is compassion

Easily reach an unequaled greatness.

If, with a pure intention, even once,
One looks upon you in the proper way,
Even through that, one will surely attain
The accomplishment of meaningful seeing.

For all the heroes whose very nature
Delights in the benefit of others,
You are the one who nurtures them and gives them birth:
You are their loving mother.

Because the buddhas, the lords of the world,
The compassionate ones, are your children,
Therefore, virtuous lady, you
Are the grandmother of all sentient beings.

The stainless perfections
Follow you, whom none disparage,
At all times,
As the constellations follow the crescent moon.

In keeping with the beings to be trained,
The various tathāgatas
Praise you, who are one alone, in many forms,
With a variety of names.

Like drops of dew
When they meet the light of the sun,
The arguments and faults of opponents
Perish when they meet you.

To the childish you bring fear:
When they see you, you are terrifying.
To the wise you bring relief:
When they see you, you are peaceful.

If the one whose protector you are
Has no clinging even to you,
Then how, O sole mother,
Could attachment or aversion toward others arise in such a one?

You have not come from anywhere,
And you do not go anywhere;
Therefore in no place at all
Do the wise apprehend you.

Not perceiving you in that way,
One practices through intention
And through that practice is fully liberated:
This, here, is a great wonder.

If one sees you, one is bound;
If one does not see you, one is also bound.
If one sees you, one is liberated;
If one does not see you, one is also liberated.

How wonderful! O greatly marvelous one,
Renowned lady, you are excellent;
Exceedingly hard to fathom, like an illusion,
You appear, and you also do not appear.

Relied upon without fail by the buddhas,
The pratyekabuddhas (solitary buddhas), and the śrāvakas (hearers),
You alone are the path to liberation:
It is certain that there is no other.

For the benefit of embodied beings,
Giving precedence to conventional usage,
The protectors of the world, out of love,
Have taught you, yet you also remain untaught.

Who here is able to praise you,
Signless and stainless,
You who transcend every domain of speech,
You who have no support in anything at all?

Even so, in conventional terms,
With paths of speech such as these,
Though you are not something to be praised,
By praising you we have passed utterly beyond sorrow.

Whatever virtue I have gathered
From praising the Perfection of Wisdom,
By it may the whole world without exception

Be inclined toward the Perfection of Wisdom.

The Praise of the Perfection of Wisdom, composed by the master, the noble Nāgārjuna, is complete.

It was translated by the Kashmiri paṇḍita Tilakakalaśa and the translator Loden Sherab.

Translator's Notes

• In the fourth stanza □□□□□□□ is translated as the evident reading □□□□□□□□, "relying on"; the "qualities" there render □□□ in the sense of the qualities of buddhahood. In the ninth stanza □□□ is the honorific word for "name," not the major marks of a great being. The colophon ascribes the hymn to Nāgārjuna; Sanskrit sources often attribute it to Rāhulabhadra.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.